



NARRATIVE REPORT FOR AUGUST 2025

INTRODUCTION

Kenya Keys stands as a beacon of hope and transformation in the Taru community, lighting the education path for countless students who might otherwise be left behind. Each month tells a story of resilience, opportunity, and growth and August 2025 was no exception. August was a month of remarkable progress and profound impact for Kenya Keys, with every department actively working to advance our mission of transforming lives through education. The period was marked by meaningful milestones that supported students academically and addressed their social, emotional, and personal needs, ensuring a holistic foundation for success.

This month saw 44 students successfully transition into higher education, equipped with the tools, resources, and confidence to begin their new journeys. At the same time, 180 vulnerable learners were welcomed into mentorship, receiving life skills coaching, guidance, and targeted support to safeguard their future. A robust community outreach brought together parents, teachers, and students to address pressing issues such as school dropouts, early pregnancies, and drug abuse. In contrast, vital student support programs ensured comfort, dignity, and continuity for learners facing difficult circumstances.

Together, these achievements are more than activities; they are building blocks of transformed lives, proving that every effort invested in education creates ripples of hope, dignity, and opportunity for future generations.

SPONSORSHIP DEPARTMENT

The month of August was both eventful and inspiring for the Department as we witnessed first-hand the transformational power of sponsorship at a critical point in the academic calendar.

As students across the country transitioned into new academic institutions, our sponsors' generosity ensured that our sponsored students and many of them who never believed higher education was within reach, walked proudly through the gates of colleges and universities. It is all our sponsors' support that continues to open these doors and we are forever grateful.

We are pleased to share the below highlights from this important month:

1. College and University Intake

A student stepping into college is always a dream realized, transforming their lives and their families' futures. August, in particular, stands out as a turning point, as it marks the main annual intake into higher learning institutions where most of the sponsored students prepare to take the next step in their academic journey as they transition from secondary school to colleges and universities. The Department spearheaded the preparation and admission of 44 students scheduled for the August–September intake. This comprehensive process involved gathering and submitting academic documents, applying for Higher Education Funding (HEF), and coordinating hostel bookings to ensure safe and affordable accommodation. Students were offered personalized guidance to complement the formal processes that shaped their readiness for the journey ahead. Through the personalized sessions, students were guided, encouraged, and supported, helping them understand their new responsibilities and giving them confidence as they entered a new chapter in their education.

The excitement and pride among them were deeply moving. Many students expressed heartfelt gratitude for the opportunity to continue their education; an opportunity they never imagined possible due to financial and social hardships.

Notably, some of these students were to report to their respective institutions without a parent or guardian to accompany them. In such cases, Kenya Keys staff members stepped in to personally escort and support them through the admission process. This not only ensured a smooth transition but served as a clear and powerful demonstration that Kenya Keys is committed to walking with each student every step of the way from the beginning of their academic journey to its successful completion.

For these students, the presence of a supportive adult at such a critical moment in their lives was both reassuring and empowering. It reinforced the message that they are not alone that they are part of a community that believes in their potential and is fully invested in their success.

The following two stories highlight the kinds of students transitioning into colleges and universities through the organization's support.

- Zulfa Mbeyu Hammad is a total orphan and one of the newest students admitted to Turkana University. Her journey has been marked by deep challenges, especially after recently losing her mother. The loss left her younger sibling with no choice but to stay in an orphanage, making Zulfa the only hope and source of inspiration for her. Unlike most of her elder siblings, who could not pursue education, Zulfa has broken through barriers to achieve what once seemed impossible. Her

university admission represents her personal victory and provides hope for her siblings and community. Through the support of Kenya Keys and her sponsors, Zulfa's education is a powerful reminder that dreams can still be realized despite loss and hardship.

- Peter Owili Oduor, recently admitted to Multimedia University, is a true example of resilience and determination. Raised by his single mother, who has limited literacy, Owili's journey was difficult. Despite being the third born in his family, he became the first child to finish high school after his elder sister dropped out.

Owili grew up in one of the most challenging environments for a child, where access to education and resources was scarce. Yet, through persistence, he excelled in primary school and later joined high school, determined to push forward against all odds. His college admission became a source of great pride and celebration in his village. The community viewed this achievement as a milestone for Owili and a beacon of possibility for other children. His story shows that with determination, family support, and sponsorship, even the toughest conditions can give way to success.

Thanks to our sponsors, these young people are stepping into a brighter future with confidence, dignity, and hope through your support.



Featuring above are Kenya Keys staff guiding and assisting students in different admission processes.

2. Sponsorship Applications

Sponsorship applications are a continuous process, with needy students and families regularly seeking assistance to access education. The August–September intake, one of the busiest in Kenya’s academic calendar, saw increased visits to the office for support. Each applicant was guided through the process from inquiry to submission. These rising applications reflect the growing awareness of Kenya Keys’ work and the deep need within communities for educational support.

Through the sponsorship requests, it was clear that students face difficult conditions; some risk ending their education entirely due to a lack of support, while others face the danger of being married off by their parents. For these young people, sponsorship is often the only bridge to a brighter future. While it is always tough and overwhelming to say no to the many cases that see Kenya Keys as their only hope, the organization deeply appreciates the sponsors who make it possible to say yes to the students we serve.



Mariam and James are guiding students on sponsorship applications

3. Laptop Distribution

For many students, acquiring a laptop is a distant dream, yet it has become a necessity for success in higher education. While this support is transformative, ensuring that poverty does not hinder education, the demand is far greater. In August, the laptop program provided a vital support, with 14 beneficiaries receiving devices that enabled them to access online learning, conduct research, and complete essential coursework. Priority was given to those pursuing teaching and information technology courses, where laptops are mandatory.

The excitement is always vivid when students receive this precious gift; it is an immense blessing to walk back to their humble, mud-walled homes carrying a laptop that will shape their academic future as they go

to school. By bridging this digital gap, the program ensures that new and continuing students are fully equipped to meet educational demands and compete equally with other students.

We extend our heartfelt appreciation to the generous sponsors who made these donations possible. The impact is immense not only do these laptops empower students in their studies, but they also relieve parents of the significant financial burden of purchasing such devices, which many simply cannot afford.



*Students
from
different
institutions
receiving
laptops from
Staff at the
Kenya Keys
office.*



4. Conferences

Conferences continue to serve as a vital platform for student engagement and academic support. These sessions bring together students and staff for mentorship and guidance, while providing opportunities to collect academic progress reports, gather sponsor updates, and for students to reply to letters. The Sponsorship Department successfully organized two major student gatherings:

1. The 2025 Term 2 Secondary School Students Conference, held on August 8th, brought together sponsored students, Kenya Keys staff. Beyond the Kenya Keys staff, the event was enriched by

external facilitators who engaged the students in inspiring sessions. Discussions centered on crucial areas such as good decision-making, career choices, personal discipline, resilience, and goal setting.

The impact of the conference extended far beyond academic guidance. It strengthened the students' connection with the organization, affirming its role in supporting their progress in school and walking with them in their personal growth. These gatherings serve as vital avenues for one-on-one mentorship, allowing students with specific needs to receive direct guidance and encouragement from mentors who believe in their potential.



Kabani and Mariam are facilitating the conference.

2. **Academic Watch Students Meeting (18th August 2025):** This meeting targeted students experiencing academic challenges. It was an interactive session where each student was paired with a mentor, creating space for open conversations. Students were given a listening ear to share their challenges in school, while mentors offered encouragement and practical strategies to help them overcome obstacles and improve their performance. Through the testimonies shared, it became clear that many academic struggles stem from difficult circumstances beyond the classroom. Notably, some students who were on Academic Watch in the previous term showed remarkable improvement, a clear indication of the effectiveness of the mentorship and academic conference in transforming academic performance.



Mariam and Winnie are on one with their mentees during academic watch

LIBRARY DEPARTMENT

August was a period of growth and renewed impact for the Kenya Keys Community Library. Serving as a hub of knowledge and opportunity for the Taru community, the library expanded its resources, strengthened its services, and provided a welcoming environment for learners of all ages. Key milestones included receiving and processing new book donations, documenting operations, and vibrant service desk activities that kept the library busy throughout the holiday.

1. Book Donations and Processing

At Kenya Keys, every book donation is more than just an addition to our shelves; it is an investment in unlocking students' potential and advancing our vision of transforming lives through education. In August, the library marked a remarkable milestone by expanding its learning resources through the generosity of two wonderful families, who contributed 331 new books. The donation process was diligently managed, from selecting titles to confirming deliveries. To catalog, insert call numbers and stamp them with the official library stamp.

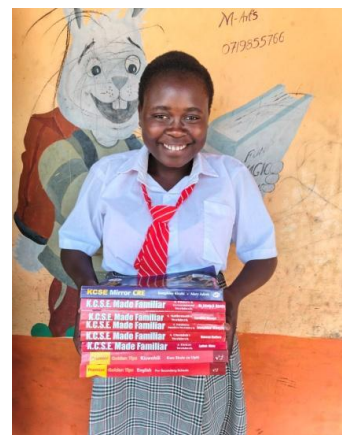
The impact of these books is big. For many students, whose homes cannot provide access to such resources, the library remains their only window to knowledge. These donations bridge gaps in access and opportunity, and stand as a lifeline of equity, ensuring that no child's potential is limited by circumstance, and that every learner who walks into the library can imagine and pursue a brighter future.



With students' help, staff happily received books at the Kenya Keys Library.



*Kenya Keys student
receiving her set of
8 revision books
from her sponsor,
Heather N. Cooke.*



2. Library Service Desk Activities

The service desk remained the frontline of impact at the Kenya Keys Community Library, ensuring smooth operations while meeting the diverse needs of learners and community members. Key responsibilities included overseeing daily circulation, assisting new readers, responding to inquiries, and conducting follow-ups on borrowed books. August, a holiday month, made the library especially busy, with many students crowding in daily for study and research. The high demand even forced students to use the library in shifts, a testament to its value and impact.

The steady flow of users highlighted the growing importance of the library as a hub of knowledge and opportunity. The month's statistics are as follows:

- Total visitors: 389
- Books borrowed: 71
- Books returned: 65
- Books renewed: 20
- Long-term loans: 6

These figures demonstrate the community's firm reliance on the library's resources. As the holiday period ended and students prepared to return to school, careful follow-ups were made to ensure that all borrowed books were returned. This ensured shelves remained stocked and ready for the next wave of learners.



Students during their personal studies at the library.



GENDER AND AFFIRMATIVE ACTION DEPARTMENT

August was marked by deep compassion, strategic support, and transformational impact for the department. Working at the heart of communities, the department continued to uphold Kenya Keys' mission of "transforming lives and enhancing livelihoods" by ensuring that gender equity and the well-being of sponsored students, especially those in vulnerable circumstances, remain top priorities. The Department addressed immediate student needs and built stronger foundations for long-term academic success, emotional resilience, and empowerment, particularly for girls and other vulnerable groups. The following are the activities and programs that the department carried out.

1. Psycho-Social Support

One of the most emotionally demanding but impactful roles this month involved psycho-social support for both Kenya Keys and non-Kenya Keys students facing traumatic family losses and crises. Two sponsored students, Samuel Mnyika John (Form 3, Taru Boys) and Aisha Luvuno Chuphi (Form 2), tragically lost their mothers in a road accident. Both are the eldest siblings in their families and were thrust into the role of caretakers. Aisha is now responsible for four younger siblings, including a seven-month-old baby. Samuel is similarly accountable for two siblings in Grades 6 and 7.

The department and other staff members rallied to provide emotional and moral support by visiting the families before, during, and after the burial, reassuring the students of continued support. These moments were heart-wrenching and tested the emotional capacity of the team, but also brought forth the deepest purpose of our work, being there when it matters most. Through counseling and mentorship, the team encouraged the students to stay committed to their education, assured them of the office's presence, and reminded them of their inner strength to overcome adversity.

Another critical psycho-social case was that of Lilian Kivindu, a student who was deeply affected by the separation of her parents due to domestic violence and substance abuse. After her father broke her mother's arm in an act of violence, the family fell apart. Lilian and her siblings were distributed to various relatives. The department offered counseling sessions and a safe space for Lilian to process her trauma, while also reinforcing her self-worth and academic potential.

In yet another instance, a non-sponsored student was brought to the office by her father seeking general life and career guidance. The team successfully guided the girl, giving her renewed hope and clarity about her future path.



Lilian, after one of the counseling sessions



The non-Kenya Keys student with her father



2. Vital student support and Usalama program.

The Vital Student Support and Usalama programs complement sponsorship by addressing students' essential needs, ensuring their comfort, safety, and well-being, and allowing them to focus entirely on their academic journey.

- **Vital student support program**

The department handled vital student support cases for continuing and newly admitted college students, including transportation, upkeep, accommodation, and graduation fees. This support is especially important for needy students, most of whom come from homes with nothing to take with them as they begin their academic journey. Without such assistance, many would struggle to report to school on time, find safe

accommodation, or even meet their basic needs. The graduation fee was given to one student, Joseph Chiwewe, who was concluding his university journey. Financial support was significant in ensuring students got to school on time, found safe and early accommodation, and met their basic needs.



Osman is filling in the VSS form.



- **Usalama Program**

The funds ensured that all students could travel safely to school, have the necessary clothing for their studies, receive medical care, and participate in educational trips that enhance their learning experience.



Ethel with her Eye Glasses.



- **Health Cases Handled**

Health remains a cornerstone of student success. This month, several cases were handled under both Usalama and Vital Student Support Programs:

- ❖ Victoria Kalinga and Ethel Chizi had serious eye problems. Victoria received corrective glasses, while Ethel had hers replaced. Faith Ndegwa was hospitalized because of pneumonia and ulcers. The office came in to help with the bills and ensured the student was served well.

- ❖ Additional support was extended to college students facing health challenges, ensuring no illness would disrupt their academic progress. These included Nicholas Kadide, who had a toothache, and Josephine Gideon, who had a case of the flu.

3. Washable sanitary distribution and Health talk

For many of our girls, a sanitary towel can mean staying in class or dropping out. Menstrual care is more than hygiene; it is dignity, confidence, and a brighter future. The department distributed 50 kits of washable sanitary towels to Kilibasi Primary School, paired with a comprehensive health talk for girls. This was done during the mentorship outreach that was carried out at Kilibasi Primary, with other students from different schools attending. The students were trained to use, maintain, and benefit from washable pads, contributing to long-term menstrual hygiene and reducing absenteeism among girls.



Distribution of Washable sanitary kits to students.

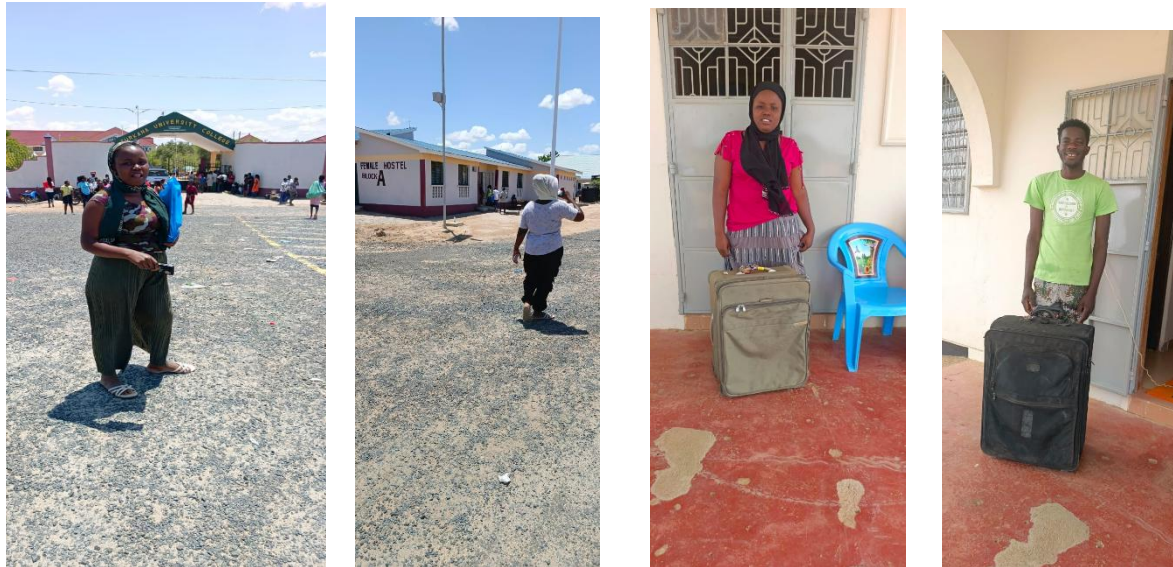
4. Student transition and initial college support

Transition from high school to college is a difficult phase, particularly for students from disadvantaged backgrounds. The department supported the sponsored students to allow a smooth transition process by;

- Suitcases (donated by USA interns) were distributed to new college students, ensuring they had the basic means to carry their belongings to school.
- Launching kits up to Ksh 30,000 to cover essentials like transportation, learning materials, and students' personal items. Students got different amounts depending on their individual situations at that moment.

- A team member escorted one student to their institution, offering mentorship and logistical support throughout the admission process.

These efforts ensured a dignified and smooth transition into college, reducing stress and setting the students up for success.



Zulfa and Mwezinane during college transition preparation.

5. Tech-Lit Program Supervision

The department continues to oversee the Tech-Lit Program in four service schools. This initiative equips students with essential digital literacy skills, bridging the technology gap and preparing them for a tech-driven world. This month, a classroom at Fuleye Primary School is being renovated as part of the preparations to include the school in the TechLit program. Once completed, Fuleye will join the growing list of Kenya Keys service schools benefiting from this transformative initiative. The students, teachers, and community have expressed deep appreciation for this partnership, noting its essential role in ensuring the mission of Kenya Keys is achieved. By expanding digital access and empowering learners with vital skills, this collaboration is a powerful example of how partnerships drive meaningful change and sustain the organization's long-term vision.



Electrical work is going on at the Fuleye Tectlit class

6. Sponsor gifts

During the June US intern visit, a sponsor left some gifts for her student, and the department offered sponsor gifts, including a special handover from the Gordons to Chibula Mbui, a Kenya Keys–sponsored college student. The moment was filled with joy, as Chibula’s excitement and gratitude were evident; her beaming smile and heartfelt appreciation reflected just how meaningful such gestures are. Beyond the physical gifts, the exchange deepened the emotional bond between sponsor and student, reinforcing the sense of connection and support that lies at the heart of the sponsorship program.



Chibula is receiving her gifts.

MENTORSHIP DEPARTMENT

In our communities, a student's education can be cut short not just by lack of fees but also by the absence of resilience, guidance, and encouragement. August 2025 was a month of real progress for the Department. Guided by Kenya Keys' vision, mentors provided steady support through life skills training, home visits and psychosocial care, ensuring students never face their challenges alone. With the added boost of the Hope Spring Kit, learners received vital resources that kept them in school.

1. Selection and Bio Taking of Hope Spring Students

August began with the launch of Phase II of the Hope Spring Initiative, a core program under the department designed to support primary and junior secondary students who face extreme vulnerability. In partnership with teachers and school administrators from each of Kenya Keys' nine service schools, students were identified based on need, personal circumstances, and potential, with equal representation of boys and girls. A detailed bio-data profile was then created for each student, capturing their backgrounds, aspirations, and challenges. This information enables mentors to deliver personalized support, ensuring interventions address real needs and empower students toward academic success and a brighter future.

2. Life Skills Coaching and Training

Life skills coaching equips students with the tools to navigate their education journey and succeed beyond the classroom. The mentors remained committed to delivering life skills training across multiple levels. Primary and junior secondary students received focused training sessions on communication and self-awareness skills during school-based Hope Spring visits. For secondary and college-level students visiting the Kenya Keys office, the life skills training took a broader approach, covering general skills such as decision-making, emotional intelligence, and personal responsibility. These sessions were instrumental in helping students develop critical life competencies that complement their academic learning and prepare them for real-world challenges.



Mentors training and engaging students on life skills during school visits



James and Winnie conducting bio taking

3. Home Visits

Home visits are a powerful bridge between mentorship and the realities students face beyond the classroom. Three important home visits were conducted during the month. One visit was to the homestead of Rachael, a current Hope Spring student residing in Nyari Village. During her bio-data interview, mentors identified her as having an exceptionally unique and complex family situation, warranting a home visit. The visit confirmed the depth of need in her household and guided mentors on how best to support her materially and emotionally.

The other two visits were to the homes of Rachael Joga and Joseph Mwangombe—both Hope Spring alumni currently in high school. These follow-up visits assessed their progress and demonstrated the long-term impact of the Hope Spring program on former beneficiaries and their families.



Nelson at Rachael Joga's homestead during a home visitWinnie during a home visit at Rachael Mwangumbo's home

4. Hope Spring Kit Distribution

Dropping out of school is a harsh reality many vulnerable students face, but timely support can change that story. In August, the department extended financial and material support through the Hope Spring Kit initiative, which proved to be a lifeline for many students, addressing critical needs that often determine whether a child stays in school or drops out. The program lifted heavy burdens from families facing unimaginable challenges by providing school fees, uniforms, and direct household support. For some, this support meant the difference between survival and giving up entirely on education. The students who received the kits were overjoyed, their excitement clearly visible as hope was restored. The support boosted their self-esteem and enhanced their participation in school, reminding them that there are people who care in times of need. It became a powerful message that their futures are still bright, and their dreams remain within reach.

Parents and guardians also expressed deep gratitude, as the support eased some of their heaviest burdens. For families struggling to make ends meet, knowing their children's education could continue brought peace of mind and renewed determination. We support students today and invest in their futures by lifting these weights. Through them, the cycles of poverty will be broken, and brighter generations will rise.



Before and after photos of students from Fuleye Primary School who benefited from the Hope Spring kit.

5. Outreach Program

Outreach programs are powerful tools for breaking cycles of vulnerability and safeguarding education.

One of the most impactful events of the month was the **Kilibasi Outreach Program**, conducted on August 19th at Kilibasi Primary School.

Kilibasi was selected as the venue for this outreach because it represents some of the most pressing challenges faced by students in rural communities. The region has consistently recorded low transition rates to high schools, colleges, and universities, leaving many young people unable to break the cycle of poverty. Students here are further burdened by extreme financial hardship, often forced into absenteeism when they cannot afford school fees. The community also struggles with widespread drug use, cultural barriers that hinder educational progression, and alarming rates of teenage pregnancies and school dropouts. Girls, in particular, face additional disadvantages, including low self-esteem and limited access to essential menstrual products—factors that directly impact both attendance and performance. By bringing the outreach to Kilibasi, Kenya, Keys sought to provide immediate relief and resources and address these issues head-on, ensuring students are given hope and a tangible pathway toward a brighter

future. This event brought together students from primary and secondary schools, teachers, parents, and Kenya Keys staff. The day's activities included mentorship sessions covering academics, life skills, and sexual reproductive health. Students also participated in co-curricular activities, received various incentives such as sanitary towels (washable and disposable), bathing and laundry soaps, books, and pens, and shared a communal meal.

Impacting 232 students in a single day is a powerful demonstration of how targeted interventions can change the trajectory of young lives. All stakeholders highly appreciated the outreach program. It created a strong sense of community, increased awareness of key issues among students, and provided much-needed personal care items to those in need. This initiative demonstrated how integrated mentorship, education, and health awareness can bring lasting transformation.



The Kilibasi primary school deputy headteacher addressing the students



James speaking of drug and substance abuse

Conclusion

August 2025 was a defining month for Kenya Keys, underscoring the organization's unwavering commitment to education, mentorship, and holistic student support. From facilitating smooth transitions into college and university to equipping learners with vital tools like laptops, uniforms, and school fees, every intervention reflected our belief that no child should be denied the chance to learn. Outreach programs and mentorship initiatives reinforced academic focus and the emotional resilience and life skills necessary to navigate real-world challenges. Meanwhile, psychosocial support extended to students facing family crises demonstrated the depth of care and humanity at the heart of Kenya Keys' mission.

As we look ahead, the progress achieved in August is both a reminder and an inspiration—that transforming lives through education requires consistent dedication, strategic collaboration, and compassionate action. Together with our partners and supporters, we remain committed to creating pathways of opportunity for every learner.

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